

Can a Machine Be Honored? AI Avatars, Ancestor Worship, and What Families Owe the Dead

From Ritual Tradition to Digital Replicas

In Vietnamese culture, it has always been a tradition to hold a death anniversary, which has helped form the foundation of Vietnamese culture and identity. Additionally, a death anniversary isn't just a simple memorial, but rather living relatives treat it as a period of communication between the living and the dead, made possible by rituals that address a departed relative. This duty is part of a larger idea called *Hiếu*, or filial piety, which requires children to honor their parents both while they are alive and after they die. With the increase in AI technology, the concept of a griefbot was first popularized in 2016 by the tech startup Luka, which created a digital replica of a deceased individual using text message history (Newton). Today, independent companies in Vietnam and regional funeral service projects like Nirvana Asia's "EternA.I." have started building on this tradition ("AI Virtual Avatar"). With the use of custom voice-cloning engines from developers like Vbee or FPT.AI, they train avatars on a deceased parent's personal letters and recorded voice so a family can hear a version of that voice responding during a ceremony ("Vbee Voice Cloning"; "FPT.AI Voice Maker").

The Dilemma AI Creates

However, even if the AI system offers comfort, a complicated dilemma arises. To be more specific, death anniversaries rely on a strict separation of the living and spirit worlds, which are connected only by complicated rituals rather than by AI simulation. Consequently, introducing AI simulation raises questions about what filial piety actually means. More specifically, if *Hiếu* is a moral duty directed toward a real person, using a chatbot means that a family might pay respect and honor to a machine learning model instead of an ancestor. As a result, an AI avatar may create a problem in which an act from relatives meant to show respect might devalue the relationship. This essay further explores the complications that arise from using AI avatars as a way to honor departed loved ones.

The Confucian Argument

Offering as If the Spirit Were Present

One compelling argument stems from Confucius, a Chinese philosopher. In the *Analects*, he explained that a person should make an offering to the dead as if they were present (Confucius 3.12). Consequently, this shifts the focus away from proving a spirit exists and onto the sincerity and respect of the living person for

the deceased relative. Therefore, a ritual only works when a person's emotional effort actually creates the feeling of presence.

According to Confucius, ritual (Li) acts as a discipline for self-cultivation, forcing a person to generate Jing (reverence) and Cheng (sincerity) when facing loss. Under this concept from Confucius, sincerity requires a person to do the heavy emotional and moral work of honoring a parent in their absence. Consequently, when a family introduces a chatbot that simulates a parent's voice, they externalize that process. Instead of cultivating deep filial respect within their own feelings, they rely on an engineered tool to mimic a relationship, which, according to Confucius, destroys the spiritual value of death rituals. By making the simulation do the work of making a parent feel present, the technology hinders the internal moral development that Confucius argued a ritual is supposed to provide.

Martin Buber on I-Thou and I-It

Two Ways of Relating to the World

Martin Buber, an Austrian philosopher and educator, offers another point of view. In *I and Thou*, a philosophical book written by Martin Buber and published in 1923, he argued that a person can relate to the world in two different ways. In an I-It relationship, a person treats whatever is in front of them as an object or tool that can be used or studied. On the other hand, in an I-Thou relationship, a person meets another being directly, as a full and real person, not as a tool serving a purpose (Buber 3–4). Buber believed that only an I-Thou relationship carries spiritual meaning, because it requires an actual person on the other side who can interact and have feelings for another person.

Why a Griefbot Stays an It

From this argument, Buber's idea shows that AI avatars do not add any real spiritual weight. The reason behind this is that AI avatars are known to build responses from a preprogrammed set of old letters and recordings. This means that griefbots have no awareness of the family member speaking to them and no inner thoughts of their own when receiving comments from family members. Buber's argument suggests that no matter how sincerely a person speaks to that avatar, the relationship stays an I-It one, because a program built from data cannot become an I-Thou relationship (Buber 3–4). All in all, based on Buber's argument, the concept of a griefbot cannot replace the spiritual value that traditional rituals offer. Overall, Buber warns us that the use of griefbots during death ceremonies risks converting an ancestor into a tool that can be utilized to comfort family members, which is the core idea of an I-It relationship.

Counterpoint: The Ethics of the Digital Afterlife

Recent scholars studying griefbots argue that the real ethical concern has little to do with whether an avatar counts as a genuine spiritual presence. Tomasz Hollanek and Katarzyna Nowaczyk-Basińska, who study the ethics of digital afterlife technology, argue that the main issues should be about the benefits and ethical

conditions that the griefbot brings. More specifically, they propose asking essential questions: whether the deceased person agreed to being digitally recreated, whether a company is profiting off a family's grief, and whether the avatar helps a person process a relative's loss (Hollanek and Nowaczyk-Basińska). With this concept, a griefbot could still be beneficial for death anniversaries as long as it is ethical and functional, meaning that the deceased relative has given permission for the creation of an AI avatar, and that the AI avatar truly helps the family remember and respect their departed loved ones. Overall, for Hollanek and Nowaczyk-Basińska, as long as the AI avatar is benefiting members within a death anniversary, it would hold spiritual weight without having to be conscious or have emotions towards relatives.

Holding the Views Together

Two Standards for Judging the Technology

When looking at this topic from a wider scope, the debate reveals two fundamentally different ways of evaluating digital afterlife technology. On one hand, Confucius and Martin Buber point out that genuine rituals require internal moral effort and active personal presence. Additionally, these philosophers stated that programmed software is not capable of providing the devotion that filial piety is expected to have. Conversely, Hollanek and Nowaczyk-Basińska focus more on the practical outcomes by judging the effectiveness of a griefbot based on its ability to offer emotional support and help families honor the deceased person.

Ultimately, when one asks whether Vietnamese families should use AI griefbots during death anniversaries, the answer depends on how a family defines respect. More specifically, if a ritual relies completely on a relative's own heart to bridge the gap between life and death, then an automated voice might weaken the respect a family is trying to show. This is because a chatbot can replicate a parent's words but cannot produce the sincere moral duty required for *Hiếu*. On the other hand, if respect for a family means keeping the memory of a parent alive and finding comfort during a difficult time, then the chatbot can be extremely useful. The technology itself does not contain any real spiritual values; rather, it acts as a tool to facilitate the process of honoring and remembering a deceased relative.

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